

GUN

Fill yer saddlebags and git on yer horsies—we's gonna have us a good ol' round o' revenge!

Evenin', y'all (or Mornin', or Afternoon, as the case may be). This here is the story of one Colton White—a simple Montana stereotype, happy to spend his days huntin' game with his old pa.

You've heard this one a gazillion times already—average young 'un thrown into a world of "brutality, greed and lust" (to quote the box-cover), who must avenge wrongdoing with the help of a well-endowed lady of flexible morals.

Well, not exactly. Colton and pa Ned are unfortunate passengers on a riverboat overrun by renegades led by Reverend Reed, an... unconventional... man of the Cloth. Before heroically sacrificing his life, Ned hands Colton a token—a pass to the Alhambra, the elite bordello in Dodge City, whence he must begin his adventure, directly linked to a mysterious artefact whose secret dies with Ned.

Gun's storyline is right up there with some of the more engaging stories of the game world:

mystery, double-crossing, pretty girls—they're all there. You're

taken through the journey with more cutscenes than you'd wish, but there's an upside. We have to give a comradely pat-on-the-back to Neversoft for nailing the voice-acting right on the head. Even better, you aren't bombarded with the awfully clichéd dialogues and random Western "buzzwords." Accents aren't artificially thick either, so rest assured—you won't be hearing taunts involving the colour of your belly and/or liver. The graphics aren't really as good as we'd expected, but the attention to detail—leathery, scarred skins and so on—is impressive.

You don't always need to follow the story if you don't want to—Gun offers you many side-missions, including taking down wanted criminals, healthy poker games and some gold mining, too. The entertainment value of these missions is limited: they finish faster than you can think of a corny Clint Eastwood quote.

You'll be gun-(obviously)-fighting against the scum of Dodge and Empire City, as well as the Apaches, making for a nice variety between the brutish Americans and the swift and deadly Indians.

The guns themselves are quite realistic, but the auto-aim feature on all weapons is insultingly forgiving. Aim a goodish bit away from a guy's ear, and you'll still blow his head apart—did they think we play games with blindfolds on?

If you want to get rid of the bad guys all quick 'n' all, use the QuickDraw mode—Gun's own version of... you guessed it...

Bullet Time! To save time in the QuickDraw, though, there's a nifty feature that lets you quickly target the next enemy for a quick kill—so you get the chance to maximise your bullet-time kill count. To keep adding to your QuickDraw meter, you need to score as many headshots as possible.

Combat is considerably gory, with generous doses of exploding

Minimum System Requirements:
Windows 2000/XP, Pentium III 1.8 GHz or Athlon XP 1800+ or higher processor, 256 MB RAM, 100% DirectX 9.0c-compliant 32 MB video card
Developer: Neversoft
Publisher: Activision
Distributor: Worldwide CD ROMs
Contact: 022-56973895
Price: Rs 999

heads and spilling brains, and the bloodthirsty will especially relish the gushing fountains of blood that spew forth during a melee attack with a trusty knife.

And now our favourite part—horse-riding! It's one of the few unique things about the game, and was the first thing we'd expected to go wrong. Instead, you are treated to one of the most fun you're going to have outside of real horse-riding. You can battle from atop your steed with surprising ease, too. What's more, you can even use it to trample your enemies to death—it's plenty of fun to watch them bounce across the landscape like little rag dolls.

Gun will probably keep you occupied no longer than two or three days: the story isn't quite as long as one would hope. There are also plenty of annoyances, like the bizarre boss-fights—where you'd use two bullets to kill a regular bandit, bosses die with 20; that's about it. The good does surpass the bad, though, making it worth a good few hours of your time. ☐

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